

OPS-RB-006 - Peak and Promotional Event Operational Readiness Checklist

Operational Checklist | Operations

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Department	Operations	Classification	INTERNAL
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1. Purpose

This checklist is used before a seasonal peak or a promotional event to establish whether the platform and the participating sellers are ready, and to produce a written readiness statement with a named owner for any residual risk.

It exists because two incidents in 2026 demonstrated that capacity problems and release problems concentrate around traffic peaks, and that informal readiness assessment produced neither a decision nor an owner.

2. Scope

Applies to	Does not apply to
Festive and seasonal peaks	Normal daily operation
Seller flash sales and promotional events	Marketing campaigns with no traffic concentration
Platform-wide merchandising events	Individual listing promotions

An event is in scope where expected peak traffic exceeds 3 times the trailing 30-day peak, or where a seller has declared an event under a contractual capacity notice.

3. Preconditions

- The event is declared with a date, a duration and an expected traffic profile.
- Declaration is received at least **10 working days** before the event.
- A readiness owner is named in Operations.
- Participating sellers are identified.

Where an account carries a contractual capacity notice requirement, a late declaration is itself a finding and must be recorded. The platform cannot assess readiness for an event it learns about when the traffic arrives.

4. Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Operations readiness owner	Runs the checklist, issues the readiness statement
Engineering	Capacity assessment, load validation, freeze compliance

Role	Responsibility
Support	Cover roster and escalation readiness
Business	Accepts residual risk, or requires the event be rescheduled
Seller counterpart	Declares the profile, confirms client-side readiness

5. Checklist

5.1 Capacity

#	Check	Evidence required
C-1	Expected peak traffic profile received from the seller	Written profile: concurrency, order rate, catalogue breadth
C-2	Capacity model run against the declared profile	Model output with a sufficient or insufficient verdict
C-3	Scaling actions identified and scheduled	Named action with an owner and a date
C-4	Load test executed at a minimum of 3x declared peak	Test report
C-5	Dependency degradation scenario tested	Test showing graceful degradation, not cascade
C-6	Load shedding verified: 429 with Retry-After, not 503	Test evidence

5.2 Client Readiness

#	Check	Evidence required
K-1	Seller client uses bounded retries with backoff and jitter	Seller confirmation
K-2	Seller client honours Retry-After	Seller confirmation
K-3	Seller client has a circuit breaker	Seller confirmation
K-4	Seller distinguishes retryable from non-retryable failures	Seller confirmation

Where client readiness cannot be confirmed, platform-side load shedding becomes the only protection. Record this as a residual risk with a named acceptor; do not treat an unconfirmed client as a readiness pass.

5.3 Change Control

#	Check	Evidence required
F-1	Change freeze window defined and communicated	Freeze dates published
F-2	No release of a cross-instance data contract change inside the window	Release plan review
F-3	Any freeze exemption approved with a written rationale	Exemption record

#	Check	Evidence required
F-4	Rollback path confirmed for anything deployed close to the window	Rollback plan
F-5	No irreversible schema migration scheduled inside the window	Migration schedule review

5.4 Data Pipelines

#	Check	Evidence required
D-1	Feed freshness within requirement for all participating sellers	Freshness metric readings
D-2	All scheduled jobs pinned to an explicit timezone	Configuration review
D-3	Consumer lag at baseline with alerting active	Lag metric readings
D-4	Data quality rejection rates at normal levels	Rejection report
D-5	Inventory position verified against seller source	Reconciliation evidence

5.5 Fulfilment

#	Check	Evidence required
L-1	Label generation providers healthy	Synthetic check results
L-2	Backup provider credentials valid and not near expiry	Credential expiry report
L-3	Live failover test executed within the last quarter	Test record
L-4	Dispatch capacity confirmed against expected volume	Seller confirmation
L-5	Reverse logistics capacity considered	Seller confirmation

5.6 Monitoring and Alerting

#	Check	Evidence required
M-1	Alert thresholds capable of detecting partial degradation	Threshold review
M-2	Alerts routed to a staffed on-call	Roster
M-3	Settlement variance detection active	Control status
M-4	Account risk rules reviewed for false-trigger exposure	Rule review

Check M-1 deserves attention. A success-rate alert set to catch outages will not fire on a 7 percentage point degradation, which is enough to cost thousands of orders during a peak.

Check M-4 exists because an automated account suspension triggered during a recovering metric in September 2026. Before a peak, confirm that risk rules cannot suspend a participating seller on stale data.

5.7 People

#	Check	Evidence required
P-1	Support cover roster for the event window	Roster with names
P-2	Engineering on-call confirmed and briefed	Roster with names
P-3	Operations recovery owner identified in advance	Name recorded
P-4	Seller counterpart contactable during the window	Contact confirmed
P-5	Escalation path and update cadence agreed with the seller	Written cadence

6. Readiness Statement

The readiness owner issues a written statement before the event containing:

1. The declared event profile.
2. The result of each checklist section: pass, pass with residual risk, or fail.
3. Every residual risk, with a named acceptor.
4. The scaling actions completed.
5. The escalation path and update cadence for the event.
6. A recommendation: proceed, proceed with conditions, or reschedule.

A statement with an unaccepted residual risk is not complete. Either someone accepts the risk by name, or the event is rescheduled.

7. Decision Points

Decision	Criterion	Owner
Accept a late declaration	Sufficient time remains for capacity assessment	Operations
Grant a freeze exemption	Change is read-only or demonstrably lower risk than deferral	Engineering lead
Accept a residual risk	Named acceptor, risk quantified	Business
Recommend rescheduling	A capacity or fulfilment check fails with no mitigation	Operations
Proceed	Statement complete, all residuals accepted	Operations with Business

8. Exceptions

An event may proceed with a failed check where a compensating control bounds the harm and Business accepts the residual in writing.

An event may proceed with fewer than 10 working days notice where the capacity model verdict is sufficient without scaling action. Record the short notice as a finding regardless.

9. Escalation

Situation	Escalate to	Timeframe
Declaration received inside 10 working days	Operations lead and Business	On receipt
Capacity model verdict insufficient and scaling not possible	Business	Within 1 working day
Client readiness cannot be confirmed	Business, for residual acceptance	Before the statement is issued
Fulfilment check fails	Operations lead	Immediately
Freeze exemption requested for a contract change	Engineering lead and Operations	Before approval

10. Post-Event Actions

- Record actual traffic against the declared profile. A profile that was materially wrong is a finding for the next event.
- Record every incident during the window and whether a checklist item had flagged the risk.
- Record whether any residual risk materialised.
- Amend this checklist where a gap is general rather than event-specific.
- Confirm the change freeze was observed.

11. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2025-09-12	Initial festive readiness checklist
2.0	2026-08-14	Extended to seller promotional events; capacity notice and readiness statement added